

Black Literature and Culture
A series edited by Houston A. Baker, Jr.

'There Ain't No Black in the Union Jack'

**The cultural politics
of race and nation**

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With a new Foreword by
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'THERE AIN'T NO BLACK IN THE UNION JACK'

and suggests a general framework for re-conceptualizing class in terms which derive from recent theories of social movements.

My overall approach necessarily involves political and theoretical opposition of the study of 'race' as an issue which is marginal to the normal processes by which British society has developed. 'Race' will be presented as an effect of a number of discourses and practices which have become more crucial to the inner workings of this society as the national crisis has deepened. In Britain, 'race' cannot be adequately understood if it is falsely divorced or abstracted from other social relations. The chapters which follow will also argue that 'race' cannot be reduced to the effects of these other relations.

1 'Race', class and agency

The race question is subsidiary to the class question in politics, and to think of imperialism in terms of race is disastrous. But to neglect the racial factor as merely incidental is an error only less grave than to make it fundamental (C. L. R. James).

Hearing . . . that you are a zealous friend for the Abolition of that Accursed traffick denominated the Slave Trade I inferred from that you was a friend to freedom on the broad basis of the Rights of Man for I am pretty persuaded that no Man who is an advocate from principle for liberty for a Black Man but will strenuously promote and support the rights of a white man & vice versa (Thomas Hardy, 1792).

This chapter is not intended to provide an account of 'race' which is designed to function as an alternative to the sociology of 'race relations' as it is presently defined.¹ However, as an introduction to what follows, a brief critique of that sub-discipline of sociology can serve to clarify some basic theoretical and political issues. It has been pointed out (Gabriel and Ben-Tovim, 1979) that sociological writing on 'race relations' falls into three categories reflecting the analysis of structures, meanings and culture. The sociology of 'race' can therefore be seen to fracture along the 'fault lines' (Craib, 1984) which traverse its parent discipline. These are the effects of the epistemological and ontological problems which arise in trying to reconcile the study of structures with the study of meaning and action.

These tensions are not confined to academic theories. They also appear in explicitly political writing on 'race' and racism. Here the most sophisticated and ambitious writers have tried to operate across these divisions. But the problems are particularly acute where writers have resisted the idea that 'race' and class belong to separate spheres of experience with different epistemological and ontological valencies and used Marxian and neo-Marxian approaches to confront the question of historical agency posed by the relationship between 'race' and class.

A non-reductive understanding of how these different collectivities interrelate has been sought by various black writers within the approach broadly suggested by C. L. R. James's words above. Hall's

* Superior figures refer to the Notes and references sections following each chapter.

use of the concept of 'articulation' (UNESCO, 1980) is, for example, an attempt to address the political and intellectual problems which arise in combining analysis of 'race' and racism as structuring relations in society with an understanding of them as ideologies shaping political action and giving it powerful common-sense meanings. The distinction between racism and racialism which emerges in the work of Sivanandan (1982) serves a similar function.

Roy Bhaskar (1979; 1980) has argued that societies and agents have different properties even if there are complex relationships of dependency between them. His position suggests that it may be useful to be more explicit about the different ways in which racism is both a property of structures and a source of meanings. He proposes a 'transformative' model of human action in which societies provide raw material for human agents to act on and thereby produce societies over time. This insight emphasizes a view of society as a process rather than a finished edifice. It can provide a framework for separating out the different analytical issues surrounding 'race'. The discourse of 'race', its ontology and the articulation between them are three interrelated aspects of a single political and theoretical problem. Their analytical separation takes place in the context of a theoretical position which can be enhanced and extended by a theory of culture. Indeed, this perspective on 'race' and racism depends on a theory which presents the cultural not as an intrinsic property of ethnic particularity but as a mediating space between agents and structures in which their reciprocal dependency is created and secured. It is, in Craib's phrase, a 'hinge linking the teleological "door" of agency to the structural frame of society' (1984).

In the sociology of 'race relations', idealists of various political persuasions have studied racial meanings as an autonomous tradition of scientific inquiry (Banton and Harwood, 1977) or in an ideological instance which, entire of itself, 'intervenes only subsequently' if at all in the economic relations of British society (Gabriel and Ben-Tovim, 1978). On the other side, there are writers who have sought to reduce 'race' to the inherent effects of various structures – relations of production, and markets (Sivanandan, 1982; Rex, 1979). Between these poles, sometimes literally papering over the stress-induced cracks, is a third tendency which has defined 'race' as a cultural phenomenon. This group has made 'race' into a synonym for ethnicity and a sign for the sense of separateness which endows groups with an exclusive, collective identity (Lawrence, 1982). For these writers, blacks live not in the castle of their skin but behind the sturdy walls of discrete ethnic identities.

This book aims to highlight some of the limitations in each of these approaches. It criticizes their conceptualizations of culture and provides an extended argument, both implicit and explicit, that a materialist theory of culture has much to contribute to 'race relations'

analysis. The initiative must be recaptured from those whose view of culture is less supple, more absolute and reluctant to address the complex syncretisms which have been a feature of the junction between 'race' and class in contemporary Britain.

Culture can be presented as a field articulating the life-world of subjects (albeit de-centred) and the structures created by human activity. However the contemporary tendency towards ethnic absolutism, explored in Chapter 2, comes to view it as an impermeable shell, eternally dividing one 'race' or ethnic group from another. Apart from the theoretical difficulties with this position, it has crucial political deficiencies. I shall argue that it replicates among black and anti-racists, positions which are characteristic of the new right.

The argument below seeks to introduce a more sophisticated theory of culture into the political analysis of 'race' and racism in Britain by claiming the term back from ethnicity. The active, dynamic aspects of cultural life have been emphasized. This is a calculated challenge to the absolutist definitions of 'race' and ethnicity which are shared by contemporary racism, a substantial current in the sociology of 'race', and much liberal anti-racism.

Racial meanings are examined not as an autonomous branch of ideology, but as a salient feature in a general process whereby culture mediates the world of agents and the structures which are created by their social praxis. These meanings are sources of the individual and collective actions which give culture its materiality. The terrain of meaning and action is also a field of historical development through struggle. The view of 'race' as an eternal, essential factor of division in society will also be challenged by showing some of the ways in which 'race' and racism have featured in contemporary Britain's complex political antagonisms, marking distinct patterns of social and political subordination and de-subordination, resistance and negotiation.

These aims take this book inevitably into areas in which various forms of class theory have made important contributions. Class analysis has helped to illuminate the contours of historical development which have seen racism change from one determinate period to the next. It is necessary then to clarify how the concepts 'race' and class will be used below and how they will be thought to combine and contradict. The final chapter argues in detail that the vocabulary of class analysis may itself be insufficient to address the political struggles charted in Chapters 3, 4 and 5. It is useful, therefore, to begin with a critical evaluation of the work of some of the writers who have tried to bring the terms 'race' and class into some sort of mutual relation.

Though its presence makes life difficult for the theorist, the concept of class cannot be entirely banished from inquiries into racial politics,

not least because it has an obvious value in locating the practice of racial groups in relation to the contradiction between capital and labour. However, where forms of political action develop which demand more than the reappropriation of material production, and where that production and the accumulation of capital depend not on exploitation alone but on control of information and communication systems, its use must be carefully specified. It is important to recognize the difficulties which attend the concept and to appreciate that its use in the politics and history of Britain's black settlers has often been economistic and reductive, seeking to subordinate the self-organization of blacks to the mythical discipline of a unified working class and its representative political institutions.

Theoretical and political debates over the status of 'race' relative to class exemplify a more general crisis in the field of Marxist analytical writing. This has its roots not only in the strategic political crises of the workers' movements in the overdeveloped countries (Mouffe and Laclau, 1985; Gorz, 1982) but also in the theoretical challenges posed for class-based analysis by writers and thinkers from radical traditions struggling against forms of subordination which are not obviously or directly related to class. These may be based on gender, 'race', ethnicity or age and are often found in political locations removed from the workplace. Mass unemployment and consumer-oriented people's capitalism have combined in novel ways to further undermine both the theory and practice of the left. Marx's own method ought to have taught his disciples that there are necessarily historical and political limits to the validity of his insights. Unfortunately some of the most anachronistic strands in Marxian thought have lived on like residual dinosaurs in the lost valley of 'race relations' analysis.

At the structural level, it has become imperative to question the analytic priority accorded by the Marxian tradition to forms of production which directly generate surplus value. This priority is no longer justified either by the diminishing size or the political character of this group of workers. Less than 30 per cent of Britain's working population now performs work of this type.

The failure of these workers to match the predictive logic of reductive Marxism and constitute a socialist vanguard, advancing towards the transformation of society, has been recently underlined. The masculinism and craft traditions which distinguish them as a group have been successfully appealed to by the family-centred populist ideology of Thatcherite conservatism. Bea Campbell (1983) puts it bluntly: 'The Tories have claimed [the] tradition of male craft and sex chauvinism, so important in the organization of the working class men's movement, for the right.'

Millions of women (who now form 40 per cent of the total working population) and low-paid workers have now been unionized in the public sector. Here the junction between 'race', gender and organized

class politics is being encountered as an urgent problem. The immediate issues raised by the presence of women, blacks and other subordinate groups in the political institutions of the working class carry with them profound theoretical questions which reach into the heart of Marxian explanation. What is the working class today? What gender is it? What colour is it? How, in the light of its obvious segmentation, is it to be unified? Is this unification still possible or even desirable?

The relationship between manufacturing and service work, the role of the state as an employer and as a provider of income, and the growth of structural unemployment, all indicate the need to rework contemporary class analysis and the conceptions of class struggle which support it. Class analysis must be opened up so that it can be supplemented by additional categories which reflect different histories of subordination as well as the 'historical and moral' elements Marx identified as determining different values for different types of labour power (*Capital I* quoted by G. Rubin, 1975).

A third of Britain's workforce is now employed by the state in central or local government as well as in publicly owned corporations. The complex experiential chemistry of class, 'race' and gender revealed, for example, by examination of public sector employment, yields an important reminder of the limitations of analysis based exclusively on a narrow conception of class. Where the conditions of subordination constructed by these forms of oppression are lived out, they cannot be empirically disentangled.

Feminist critiques of Marxism have emphasized the political privileges attached by it to work outside the home and the way it has devalued labour performed in the private sphere. They point towards the same critical conclusion even when, as in some socialist feminist writing, a reconstruction of class theory is proposed.² If class analysis is to retain a place in explaining contemporary politics in general and the relationships between black and white workers, citizens, neighbours and friends in particular, it must be ruthlessly modernized.

Though it is a necessary part of the analytic framework proposed here, the contradiction between capital and labour is not sufficient; it simply cannot by itself generate a complete account of the struggles through which the social movement of blacks dissolves and then transcends the formal divisions of class. In some struggles, workers and shopkeepers have created political solidarity in the name of 'race' and community. In others, the action of black workers may be linked in complex ways to those of the black unemployed. It has been suggested, for example, that the industrial action in which health service workers confronted the government during the autumn and winter of 1982-3 cannot be understood unless the issue of its relationship to the urban protests of summer 1981 is explained. The Race

Today Collective have argued that these two apparently distinct conflicts can be shown to have common roots not simply in the black populations that spearheaded them, but in a self-conscious community's struggles against various, different manifestations of pauperization. The political activities of black workers in the health service are necessarily tied to those of their children in the streets.³

This example illustrates the need for a political and theoretical vocabulary capable of linking the organization of service workers to that of unemployed young people. It underlines the fact that there is nothing to be gained from attempts to use the concept class as if its meaning had been unaffected by the changes in capital accumulation and the division of labour which have resulted from the revolution in new technology.

The place of black labour in the processes which transform workers into a class and distribute surplus labour power in society raises a series of fundamental doubts about the degree of homogeneity which can be ascribed to today's 'English working class'. It is severely divided not only between those in and out of work, but between workers in the various sectors of waged employment, between men and women, and between older and younger people. Conflicts around 'race', nation and ethnicity must be examined in the light of these other divisions where the unity of a single 'working class' cannot be assumed but remains to be created. It must be emphasized, then, that class is used below in a tentative and even provisional manner. The concept is useful to the extent that it ties political struggles to the goal of reappropriating the material structures of production but the antagonisms which form around 'race' and racism are not limited by this aim. Accordingly, class has been shorn of the positivistic certainties which came to be associated with it in the period when industrial production was ascendant. These are now an outmoded, residual presence in both sociological writing on 'race' and socialist political analysis of racism.

Race for itself and class in itself

Writers who have tried to theorize the relationship between 'race' and class in contemporary Britain can be divided into three basic tendencies. These form around the same 'fault lines' which divide the sociologies of systems from the sociologies of action. Each features a distinct paradigm or problematic for the 'race'/class relationship and each is marked by an equally clear political orientation.

The first tendency operates on the boundaries of Weberian and Marxist analysis and argues that economic relations have a primacy in determining the character of 'race' politics. In its Weberian inflection, it views blacks as members of an 'underclass' (Rex and

Tomlinson, 1979) while in the parallel Marxist version, this idea is conveyed by the term 'sub-proletariat'. The point of departure for both variations is recognition of the ways in which Britain's black populations are subject to particularly intense forms of disadvantage and exploitation. For the Weberians, an underclass status results from the accumulated effect of losing struggles in the distributive sphere. In other words, faring consistently badly in the markets for jobs, housing and education. This structural position constitutes the objective basis for an 'underclass in itself'. This appears where 'instead of identifying with working-class culture [my emphasis] community or politics they [the blacks] formed their own organisations and became in effect a separate under-privileged class' (Rex and Tomlinson, 1979, p. 275).

The version of this argument, which is cast in Marxist language, lays greater emphasis on the effect of *production* relations in generating and reproducing the underclass/sub-proletariat with its distinct political identity. Racial structuration is thus imposed by capital. But it is compounded and deepened by the state institutions and agencies which seek to regulate the ebb and flow of black labour power in capital's interests. Thus, the role and position of migrant labour in late capitalism as well as the political and legal contradictions around citizenship and settlement in Britain have been important objects of concern to this tendency.

The value of these arguments lies in their insistence on the real effects of racial division inside the working class and in the suggestion that sectional class interests expressed along the lines of 'race' and colour are not epiphenomena of capitalist development and cannot therefore be banished by incantation of the voluntaristic slogans like 'black and white unite and fight'.

In the Marxist version of this approach, the term sub-proletariat is noteworthy because it allows black leftists a means to retain a significant but vague link with class theory. This link has a rhetorical dimension as well as an analytical one. It encourages activists to open a dialogue with the political forces of 'the left' while directing their energies towards the development of relatively autonomous black political activity, focused by the ways in which racism reaches into the lives of the black working class. Whereas, for the Weberian writers, market relations secure and reproduce the divisions between the racially distinct underclass and the class structure as a whole, Marxists address the effects of racist ideology and racist practice which fracture the political superstructure and the economic base in turn. The most sophisticated version of the Marxian variation on these themes is found in the work of Sivanandan. He describes the relationship between racism and capitalism as an essentially instrumental and even functionalist one in which 'Capital requires racism not for racism's sake but for the sake of capital' (1980). Where

capitalism depends on racism in this way, and this is Sivanandan's analysis of post-war Britain, struggles against racism become a priori struggles against capitalism.

Both versions of this argument see the transposition of struggle between economic and political levels of the social formation as a straightforward question. 'Race' conceived in class terms acts as a conductor between the two.

The second analytical tendency which can be identified claims its warrant from the rigours of political economy and in the name of Marxian science, sets out to outflank the first position from the left. This approach has been typified in the recent work of Robert Miles. His position begins by emphasizing the familiar observation that 'races' as they appear in society have no basis in the raw materials of human biology.⁴ There is, of course, only one human race, but for Miles this observation is entangled with a demolition of the sociology of 'race relations' and becomes the trigger for an intense critique of all attempts to use the concept 'race' in either description or analysis. It is as if the recognition of the limited value of 'race' as an analytic tool provided, in itself, a coherent theory of contemporary racisms. Miles writes on occasions as if he believes that banishing the concept 'race' is a means to abolish racism:

I recognize that people do conceive of themselves and others as belonging to 'races' and do describe certain sorts of situation and relations as being 'race relations', but I am also arguing that these categories of everyday life cannot automatically be taken up and employed analytically by an inquiry which aspires to objective or scientific status (1982, p. 42).

In a later work (Miles, 1984), the complex and contradictory ways in which actual social forces recognize themselves as 'races' and organize themselves in political life on the basis of constructed racial sensibility are brushed aside in what amounts to an attempt to reduce the complexities of social life to a set of theoretical concepts.

The supposed dichotomy between 'race' and class becomes a mere 'false construction' (Miles, 1984) and '... the totality of "black people in Britain" cannot be adequately analysed as a "race" outside or in opposition to class relations'. 'Race' is nothing more than an ideological effect, a phenomenal form masking real, economic relationships in a manner analogous to a mirage. To use 'race' in analysis and thus to respect the diverse ways in which it endows action with meaning is to capitulate to mere ideology. Miles therefore attacks black writers who have initiated a dialogue with Marxism over racism in Britain because they use 'race', in spite of its illusory status, to 'encourage the formation of a particular political force'. He clearly disagrees with the political strategy these authors propose and makes his disagreement explicit through a negative evaluation of the politics of black autonomy. The idea is to be dismissed not only

because it is based on idealist theoretical foundations but because it represents a political threat to a deeper class unity:

... the political and ideological reaction of those who remain the object of racism will be increasingly a movement towards a complete break with the struggles and institutions that arise of out production relations. Once this happens, the politics of 'race' are likely to predominate amongst those excluded by racism, leading to a strategy of absolute autonomy (Miles, 1984, pp. 231-2).

Miles describes racism and racialization as having 'autonomous but limited effects' but does not specify how much autonomy his own political strategy will cede to blacks in Britain.

Racism, it is argued, originates and is reproduced in particular forms of the struggle between capital and labour – specifically in the modern period, the employment of migrant labour. Thus although racism is rigorously defined in terms of the Marxian theory of ideology, it becomes a problem which can be solved satisfactorily at the economic level. Here, shared class positions in the processes of production provide 'a material and political basis for the development of anti-racist practice within the working class'. This position effectively articulates a theoretical statement of the 'black and white unite and fight' variety. The consciousness of groups which define themselves in, or organize around, what become racial discourses is rendered illegitimate because of its roots in ideology. It is consistently counterposed to the apparently unlimited potential of an ideal category of workers. This group, the repository of legitimate and authentic class feeling, is able to transcend racial particularity in political practice uncontaminated by non-class subjectivity. Class is confined to the workplace and the pure solidarity of workers apparently flows from their position in the immediate processes of production. The form of class consciousness, which Miles identifies as non-ideological, emerges only in this narrow conception of production relations. The possibility that either the political and cultural life of 'races' or their experiences of racial subordination can become unifying factors enabling groups to act across the formal lines of class is vigorously criticized.

This perspective presents Marxism as a privileged science allowing unique access to fundamental historical issues which are denied to analysts writing from other perspectives. Dogmatism is particularly evident in Miles's discussion of class relations inside the black communities. The effects of popular and institutional racisms in drawing together various black groups with different histories is unexplored. The idea that these relationships might create a new definition of black out of various different experiences of racial subordination is not entertained. Blacks are presented, not as a potentially cohesive group but as 'a population of significantly distinct historical

origins, occupying different class positions' (Miles, 1984). A complete discontinuity is introduced between the interests of the black *petit bourgeois* and working-class black settlers on the basis of their objectively contradictory class positions. Yet the construction of the Black Community as a complex and inclusive collectivity with a distinctive political language undermines Miles's position. The formal lines of class have been blurred recently not just by the explicitly anti-racist actions of the black *petit bourgeois* which will be examined in Chapter 4, but by the struggles of black teachers, business people and even media workers.

Examining the way that these groups are formed and sometimes reproduce can point to a view of 'race' as a political category. As such, its meanings are unfixed and subject to the outcomes of struggle. There can be no guarantee that conflicts over the meaning of 'race' will always be resolved in a politically radical or progressive direction, but it would be foolish to deny the black *petit bourgeois* the capacity to 'change sides' which Marx and Engels describe so cryptically in *The Communist Manifesto* (Marx and Engels, 1973).

If journalists, teachers, sociologists and other members of the professional and managerial classes can be theorized into contradictory class locations and from there, take up the needs of the working class by joining its political institutions, perhaps even becoming its organic intellectuals, there seems no reason why the black *petit bourgeois* in both its 'old' and 'new' guises should not be able to do something similar. Indeed, common history, culture and language, as well as the effects of racism, may all enhance this possibility. For example, where neighbourhood shops acquire the role of community institutions, it is possible for their proprietors to develop a sense of the connections between their lives and those of their working-class clients. As a result, they may go on to provide them with goods on credit when they strike. This type of connection has been a notable feature of some industrial disputes, particularly where a black workforce lives in close proximity and is able to make its politics simultaneously in both work and non-workspace (Mala Dhondy, 1974).

Miles notes that common involvement of black and white workers in the trades union and labour movements can lead to common struggle. However he and Annie Phizaclea have argued for a complete separation between this 'class unity' and various forms of ethnic organization (1980). I shall try and demonstrate that the language and culture of black radicalism is more complex in its relation to class than this simple polarized schema suggests.

Phizaclea and Miles also find it hard to grasp that what they call 'ethnic organization' is not reducible to anti-racism. I shall show in Chapters 4 and 5 that anti-racism is not and probably has never been an adequate heading under which the content, scope and direction of black protest and self-organization can be assessed. Black political

action has often been articulated through what appears to be a utopian political language. The distance from economism which has characterized it has baffled critics who would measure it by Eurocentric yardsticks and are consequently unable to perceive the sophisticated critique of capitalism which informs the social movement of blacks in the overdeveloped countries. This critique has, in Richard Wright's words, 'become a tradition, in fact a kind of culture' (Padmore, 1956). This social movement has a variety of goals other than the elimination of racist ideology.

In any case, looking at the contradictions in political consciousness formed at work tells less than half the story. Work is not the only place where complex and important political relationships between black and white Britons have been created. 'Race' can be shown to be relevant to the politics of consumption as well as to the politics of production, and Chapters 4 and 5 below look at some of the connections between black and white youth in detail as part of an argument that the issue of 'race' has become a central theme and referent in virtually all youth cultures in this country.

Miles and his collaborators regard the dissolving of 'race' into class as a necessary and desirable step. The third tendency which can be identified shares the idea of a fundamental split between 'race' and class but argues for the opposite strategic conclusions. For writers in this group, the distance between 'race' and class is the result not of their different epistemological values in Marxist science but of the fact that racism inhabits a general ideological instance in the social formation. It does not appear to have any contact with class politics. The task of the radical theorist of 'race' and racism is revealed as the production of critiques of official 'race' policy and the formulation of alternative 'rational policy recommendations' which can facilitate the 'rational political interventions' of central and local governments (Gabriel and Ben Tovim, 1979). There are several problems, both political and theoretical, with this position. Its plausibility relies on a positive evaluation of the capacity of state institutions to act as an agent for the elimination of racism. This cannot be taken for granted at either level of government. We shall see, in Chapter 4 for example, that even where a progressive, radical local authority acts in the name of anti-racism its practices may reinforce the very ideologies it is seeking to challenge.

At a theoretical level, this tendency identifies 'race' in a variety of political struggles which are distinguished from class antagonisms on the basis that they are primarily 'popular democratic' and not therefore inscribed by class.

The struggle for racial equality and racial justice . . . needs to be seen primarily as a popular democratic struggle which . . . entails, in current conditions of British parliamentary democracy, a complex, detailed and

realistic war of position to be waged by the ethnic minorities and anti-racist organisations, involving the application of a consistent disposition of forces to those key areas of the local state in which constructive developments can successfully be fought for (Ben Tovim *et al.*, 1981)

The formulations 'national popular' and 'popular democratic' derive from a reading of Gramsci articulated most notably by Ernesto Laclau (1977) which I have criticized elsewhere (CCCS, 1982). They accord with the strategic thinking of the European communist parties (Balibar *et al.*, 1980). The political danger in this approach is twofold. Its enthusiasm for the language of nation and a national focus leads to the contemporary association between British racism and British nationalism being overlooked. When coupled with political pragmatism which demands from the left a populist appeal to match the authoritarian populist (Hall, 1985) appeal of the right, there is a further risk that forms of nationalism which are themselves coloured with racial connotations will be endorsed. This problem is explored in detail in the next chapter. Second, the logic of this approach reduces the construction of anti-racist politics to the development of those forms of democracy which are congruent with a pluralist national identity. Rabstein locates anti-racism in precisely this way, seeing it as the construction of a

national democratic alliance whose strategy for the democratisation of life in Britain is linked to a national liberation struggle aimed at asserting a new pluralist national identity through struggling around race issues in the first instance (1981, p. 99).

Like Miles, these authors insist on locating racism in a discrete ideological instance. They would, however, tend to disagree with his mechanistic suggestion that political conflicts can be addressed by appealing to a fundamental unity of workers based on their common class position. For this tendency, racism is bad ideology and it must be combated not, as he would have it, in the realm of economic contradictions but by good (popular democratic) ideology. This can be pumped into people's heads by a variety of means and is orchestrated by rational state intervention expressed in clearly focused policies. Race relations legislation, multi-cultural education policies and racism awareness training are some of the favoured vehicles for accomplishing this transformation. Ben Tovim *et al.* identify the means of its elaboration in the 'hegemonic' activities of 'black para-professionals'.

The difficulties I have identified in these positions involve more than simply a critique of the way that each deploys the concept 'race'. If it is accepted that one of the definitive characteristics of contemporary racism is its capacity first to define blacks in the problem/victim couplet and then expel them from historical being altogether, then anti-racism must be able to respond by revealing

and restoring the historical dimensions of black life in this country. However, none of the models of the 'race'/class relationship discussed above are adequate to this task. Despite their differences, the first two positions centre on the idea that the historical process emerges (either directly or complexly) from the 'economic' antagonisms arising out of production or market relations. The third breaks with this idea but the price of its divergence is that 'race', defined in the ideological instance, loses contact with both history and class politics. It becomes a policy issue.

Racism is not a unitary event based on psychological aberration nor some ahistorical antipathy to blacks which is the cultural legacy of empire and which continues to saturate the consciousness of all white Britons regardless of age, gender, income or circumstances. It must be understood as a process. Bringing blacks into history outside the categories of problem and victim, and establishing the historical character of racism in opposition to the idea that it is an eternal or natural phenomenon, depends on a capacity to comprehend political, ideological and economic change. It is here that a revised and reworked concept of class may be of value provided that, as I have suggested earlier, the dialectic between forces and relations of production is stripped of its nineteenth-century content and the concept is not confined to the immediate relations of production.

The three approaches I have criticized all seek to negotiate a position for 'race' and ethnicity in relation to an overarching class structure. By contrast, the path I have chosen pays less attention to the issue of the epistemological relation of 'race' to class and to the status of 'race' as a distinct order of social phenomena *sui generis*. The pursuit of a platonist answer to the question of where 'races' slide between the world of real relations and the world of phenomenal forms must, I believe, be given secondary status. The primary problem for analysis of racial antagonism which occurs within the broad framework of historical materialism must be the manner in which racial meanings, solidarity and identities provide the basis for action. Different patterns of 'racial' activity and political struggle will appear in determinate historical conditions. They are not conceived as a straightforward alternative to class struggle at the level of economic analysis, but must be recognized to be potentially both an alternative to class consciousness at the political level and as a factor in the contingent processes in which classes are themselves formed. It may be felt, for example, that in Britain during the late 1980s 'race', whatever we think of its ideological origins, provides a more potent means to organize and to focus the grievances of certain inner-city populations than the languages of class politics with which it must, in a limited sense, compete. We shall see in Chapter 2 how the voice of this class politics has acquired racial referents and connotations through its relationship to the language of nationalism. Recognizing

these developments need not lead, as it does in the work of Glazer and Moynihan (1975), to a situation in which racial or ethnic politics is crudely counterposed to class as a basis for collective action but rather to a finer discrimination which appreciates the complex interplay between struggles based around different forms of social subordination.

Class formation

Wallerstein (1979) has argued forcefully that 'class analysis loses its power of explanation whenever it moves towards formal models and away from dialectical dynamics'. To reconstruct class so that it is adequate to the task I have outlined involves turning it away from being a polarized concept and towards becoming a multi-modal one. The emphasis found in traditional Marxist writing about 'race' must therefore be inverted: 'race' can no longer be reduced to an effect of the economic antagonisms arising from production, and class must be understood in terms qualified by the vitality of struggles articulated through 'race'. However, clarification of what class consciousness and struggles consist of in contemporary Britain is, in itself, difficult. The growth of populist political forms which appeal to national sentiment, seemingly above and beyond the narrow concerns of class, has been matched by a detachment or distancing between the poor and their traditional means of political representation – the trades union and labour movements. The effect of these developments can be seen in the proliferation of political subjectivities apparently unrelated to class and often based on ascriptive criteria (age, 'race', gender). We shall see in Chapter 6 that political action premised on 'race' and openly against racism can contribute to new social movements of this type.

These shifts are part of a crisis of representation in the organizations and institutions of the working-class movement and this must be acknowledged in any revised notion of class. They render the assessment of class feeling very complex. This crisis has structural and conjunctural, national and international dimensions. Its structural aspects include not only the ways in which new technology and recession now circumscribe the range of economic options available to Britain but also the demographic factors which are associated with the uneven development of national decline. The latter has precipitated important changes in the regional bases of the working-class movement (G. Williams, 1982; Massey, 1984; Massey and Miles, 1984). These are significant because, like the politics of anti-racism, they point to the limits of a political strategy based on appeals to a homogeneous and cohesive nation.

Where the crisis of representation has been acknowledged by the

left, discussion has centred on the electoral implications of the dislocation between the represented and their representatives. In particular, the question of whether the Labour Party will be able to survive this upheaval has been explored, as has the related discussion of the peculiar qualities of Thatcherite conservatism which have enabled it to maintain a limited but none the less effective 'historic bloc'⁵ amidst the debris of deindustrialization (Hqbsbawm, 1984; 1985). These issues, however important, constitute only a fraction of the problems in which the crisis of representation is manifest. It can also be apprehended through the populist politics of 'race' and nation which has emerged at the centre of Britain's attempts to make sense of national decline.

The resultant racialization of British political life has passed through various phases since the end of the Second World War. Chapter 3 examines some of the ways in which racist ideologies have changed during this period. It is important at this stage of the argument to recognize that the populist impulse in recent patterns of racialization is a response to the crisis of representation. The right has created a language of nation which gains populist power from calculated ambiguities that allow it to transmit itself as a language of 'race'. At the same time, the political resources of the white working class are unable to offer a vision, language or practice capable of providing an alternative. They are currently unable to represent the class as a class, that is outside of the categories in which capital structures and reproduces it by means of 'race'. Where this means of representation has been articulated, as we shall see in Chapters 4 and 5, its relationship to class organization and to the languages of class politics had been tenuous.

There must be caution in any attempt to adapt Gramsci's commentary on the genesis of Italian Fascism to contemporary British conditions. However, his remarks capture something of the relationship between this crisis and the emergence of authoritarian and nationalist political forces:

At a certain point in their historical lives, social classes become detached from their traditional parties. In other words, the traditional parties in that particular organizational form, with the particular men who constitute, represent and lead them, as its expression. When such crises occur, the immediate situation becomes delicate and dangerous, because the field is open for violent situations, for the activities of unknown forces, represented by charismatic 'men of destiny' (1971, p. 210).

In contemporary Britain, the politics of 'race' has provided the site for just such a detachment. Locating 'race' and racism in a Gramscian analysis based on hegemony poses the question of class in an acute form. It points to a view of the causality of class as a complex, multi-determined process in which racialization currently plays a key part.

The positions of dominant and subordinate groups are ascribed by 'race'. It assigns and fixes their positions relative to each other and with respect to the basic structures of society, simultaneously legitimating these ascribed positions. Racism plays an active role, articulating political, cultural and economic elements into a complex and contradictory unity. It ensures, though this need not always be the case, that for contemporary Britain 'race is the modality in which class is lived', the medium in which it is appropriated and 'fought through' (Hall, 1980).

Looking at 'race' in this way underlines the contingent and discontinuous nature of class formation. Analysing it requires careful attention to the necessary displacement of 'relative autonomy' between the economic, ideological and political instances in any social formation. This problem is glossed over by the Marxian writers criticized above. The range of possible outcomes within the formation of any particular class may be determined primarily by economic considerations but 'in the last instance' it will be rooted in the results of ongoing processes of conflict. Class in concrete historical conditions is therefore the effect of struggles.

Adam Prezowski (1977) has used this insight to develop the idea that class struggle should be broadly defined. It should encompass struggles which bring classes into being as well as struggles between organized class forces which are relatively rare. His break with the economistic definitions of class characteristic of much avowedly Marxist writing on 'race' is readily apparent. He draws an important distinction between 'the determination of objective ideological and political relations by objective economic relations' and the multiplex, reciprocal relationship of determination of struggles by the structured totality of social relations. In specific historical circumstances, particular patterns of class formation involve both types of determination. Objective conditions structure the range of possibilities, but precise outcomes emerge directly from struggles. Prezowski concludes that 'all conflicts . . . can be understood in historical terms if and only if they are viewed as effects of and in turn having effects upon class formation'. This statement is offered as a methodological postulate for a complex, non-reductionist radicalism based on Marxism. It has been clarified further by Katznelson who concludes his own discussion of class thus:

Class society exists even where it is not signified; but how and why it is signified in particular ways in particular places and times is the study of class formation (1981, p. 207).

Whether this position merits the name Marxism and its precise lineage within the tradition of Marxist-humanist writing are interesting questions beyond the scope of this chapter (Thompson, 1978; Soper, 1986). However, the expanded conception of class formation

to which it refers can contribute significantly to an alternative view of the 'race'/class relationship in several ways. First, it suggests that an analysis based on class formation can render the connections between history and concrete struggles, structure and process, intelligible even in situations where collective actors define themselves and organize as 'races', people, maroons, ghost-dancers or slaves rather than as a class. Second, when struggles about class formation are being discussed, that is struggles which have the effect of organizing or dis-organizing classes, the possibility of reciprocal determination between 'race' and class politics can be identified.

The emphasis on class formation leads to the conclusion that when struggling to form and to reproduce, classes are only *potentially* constituted. It allows for the historical analysis of periods when the language and politics of class may be entirely absent, as well as periods like our own when the reappropriation of material production is only one goal among many in the heterogeneous practice of social movements. From this perspective, even the most resolutely autonomous organization of black workers, claimants or schoolchildren does not necessarily represent a simple threat to the organic unity and interests of a fixed and predetermined working class. Class politics in this model do not precede the encounter between black and white, they are created or destroyed in it. This must be the beginning of an answer to those who would relegate black struggles to the realm of 'non-class' contradictions (MacLennan, 1984) and in the process deprive them of the capacity to shape or define class antagonism (Boddy and Fudge, 1984). A class formation problematic also provides a third political and theoretical opportunity. It permits the effects of racism to be located structurally and historically in relation to the conflict between capital and labour.

One of the effects of reciprocal determination between 'race' and class struggles has been the creation of what Cedric Robinson has called a 'racial capitalism'. Without wishing to enter debates over the extent to which racial differentiation has been integral to capitalist development (Wolf, 1982), it seems important to recognize that the tendency to 'exaggerate regional, subcultural and dialectical differences into racial ones' (Robinson, 1982) has been a remarkable feature of continuity across the various economic expressions of the capitalist world system and their ideological conditions of existence. This subject has not always received due consideration in the historiography of nation states and national capitals (Linebaugh, 1982; 1984; and Sweeny, 1984).

If it is to continue to be useful, class analysis like class struggle cannot be confined to the individuals who occupy positions in the immediate processes of production, nor even to the actions of the 'collective labourer in hand and brain'. The mis-match between the quantity of labour available and the actual labour necessary for

capitalist production has created structural unemployment. This surplus labour power appears in particular social forms. Its distribution demands an acknowledgement of the political potential of groups banished from the world of work and wages. The organization (if any) of surplus populations is at the very core of class formation in contemporary Britain and involves a unique accommodation between black and white. How are groups based in the surplus population to combine if at all with the residues of the trades union and labour movements? How does political consciousness change when people move forever away from the possibility of waged work and accept the state as the provider of their income? How do the politics of 'race' and nation organize and disorganize these groups in struggle?

The effects of racialization are certainly visible in the distance between the economic marginality of surplus population and their political centrality. The riots of 1981 and 1985 are remembered as somehow racial events. Given that a minority – between 29 per cent and 33 per cent – of those arrested in 1981 were 'non-white' it is essential to ask how this memory has been constructed?

Those uprisings and the 'mini-riots' which have continued sporadically in the period between them point to the importance of the surplus population. It is prominent not only in representations of national decline but in the processes which turn workers and non-workers alike into a class, or at least into an urban social movement, conscious of its discrete collective interests at local level.

The notion of an articulated ensemble of social relations structured in dominance has been proposed by Hall (1980) as a basic concept in the analysis of racially segmented societies. It is readily compatible with the emphasis on class formation proposed here. Both express a shift away from seeing exploitation as the sole route to political consciousness and encourage consideration of the effects of subordination based in forms of power which have at best a partial and ambiguous connection with the extraction of surplus value. These include subjectivities and struggles constituted around gender, sexuality, generation, the consumption and distribution of state services and ecological and regional conflicts as well as those defined by 'race'. It is easy to see how some of these forms of struggle move beyond the particularity in which they originate. For example, whether or not it can be called feminist (Loach, 1985), the organization of women in the coal strike of 1984-5 qualified and transformed the meaning of class in that dispute and affected the ability of all social forces in support of the struggle to act politically as a group. New kinds of solidarity and new patterns of communication between different areas of the country were brought into being. Similarly the struggle of miners' dependants to claim the state benefits to which they were entitled, articulated a political connection between those whose claims were based on the strike and other claimants whose

relationship to work was more distant. These examples illustrate a process which is being repeated in smaller and less visible patterns on an every-day basis. The class element in these struggles can be defined in their commitment to the reappropriation of the material structures of production. Yet they will not be limited by this aim which is a necessary but not a sufficient means of realizing their plural desires.

Struggles over the quality and direction of urban policing which emerged in the aftermath of the 1981 riots are the most obvious recent case in which a 'sectoral' struggle often articulated around ideas about 'race' has been carried into the institutional mainstream of working-class politics.⁶ These conflicts have highlighted the contradiction between local and national governments and revealed novel links between local state bureaucracies and street-level politics, some of which will be discussed in Chapter 4. Their outcome has clear implications for the ability of all radical forces to organize and engage in political activity.

The most apparently disparate struggles can be related analytically to the processes of class formation by looking directly at their effects rather than solely at the intentions of the people who conduct them. Political antagonism is manifest in a variety of organizational forms. The class formation problematic requires that organization is viewed as a theoretical problem in its own right. If, at one level, the unity of the working class must remain a symbolic unity (Laclau and Mouffe, 1985), at another, radical and critical political organizations and movements negotiate with each other (regardless of their sectarian origins) and may even be forced in the course of a particular struggle to try and co-ordinate their actions. The institutional structure of the state plays a role here particularly in potentially unifying the various components of the surplus population. The state's institutions map out the strategic configuration of political conflicts. This is defined against them and may be unified by their operations. They provide a material context for the development of movements and organizations as well as an important basis for any relationship between them:

... institutional patterns shape mass movements by shaping the collectivity out of which protest can arise. Institutional life aggregates people or disperses them, moulds group identities and draws people into settings in which collective action can erupt ... institutional roles determine the strategic opportunities for defiance, for it is typically by rebelling against the rules and authorities that people protest. ... The unemployed do not and cannot strike even when they perceive that those who own the factories and businesses are to blame for their troubles. Instead they riot in the streets where they are forced to linger, or storm the relief centres and it is difficult to imagine them doing otherwise (Piven and Cloward, 1977, p. 22).

The form of the state structures the form of political struggles. Where

state institutions impose racial categories, the struggle against racism will be a struggle against the state. People encounter these agencies in a variety of different roles: client, critic and beneficiary as well as employee. The institutional structure of schools, housing authorities and social security offices allows the individuals involved in operating them to articulate political relationships which may require state servants to side with their 'clients' against their managers. Opposition to ethnic monitoring by DHSS staff or their strikes against the introduction of specialist claims control units illustrates this. Thus new kinds of political struggle can be solidified by the very institutions which are deployed to answer their demands and to channel them into fragmented individualized solutions: into separate cases and claims. This synchronization and unification can also be fostered by a political language which defines all those who challenge the dominant order as a common, natural enemy. Miners and blacks discover that they share being labelled 'the enemy within'.

All this is not merely a more complex way of saying that the discourses of powerless and dispossessed groups will tend to resonate for one another. That is certainly true and the depth of support for the miners' struggle in the black communities bears it out.⁷ I am suggesting that these heterogeneous struggles somehow encompass class and are in the process of moving beyond the challenge to the mode of production which defines class politics. What this means for the social movement of blacks in this country will be explored through an examination of expressive culture in Chapter 5. The general argument can be summed up like this. New types of class relations are being shaped and reproduced in the novel economic conditions we inhabit. The scale of these changes, which can be glimpsed through the pertinence of a populist politics of 'race' and nation, is such that it calls the vocabulary and analytic frameworks of class analysis into question. It emphasizes the fact that class is not something given in economic antagonisms which can be expressed straightforwardly in political formations. It no longer has a monopoly of the political stage, if indeed it ever had one.⁸

At present, narrowly class-based political action has to compete against a variety of popular politics of which the populist development that can be identified by the shorthand term the 'new racism' is only one important example. The rise of this new racism can be located in a crisis of political representation in the organizations of the working-class movement. Unless class analysis is to be restricted to those rare occasions on which self-conscious social groups articulate their political struggles through languages of class (Stedman Jones, 1983), the notion of class struggle must be redefined. Prezworski suggests that it can include struggles to form classes: struggles about what class is to be at any particular moment. Rather than being guaranteed in the inevitable progress from class in itself

to class for itself, class today is a contingent and necessarily indeterminate affair. It would, however, be mistaken to simply label any political struggle which has the potential for universalizing the issue of emancipation as class struggle. The obvious alternative, pending the replacement of class as a category in the long term, seems to be to reserve the concept for those elements within the politics of social movements which relate to the contradiction between capital and labour and to the mode of production which makes that contradiction intelligible. Social movements centred on the experience of subordination as well as exploitation include class but are not reducible to it. Where it enables political action and organization, 'race' falls into this category.

The most visible of recent changes in class relations involve the genesis of a professional and managerial class (Carter, 1985) and the expansion of surplus labour which appears in society in a number of contradictory forms: 'housewives', 'black youth', 'trainees', 'the middle class' and 'claimants'. This surplus population must be examined in its own right as a potential class and in its relationship to other classes and class fractions. However, the novelty of the conditions we inhabit means that the concept of alliances is not always appropriate to the relationships these groups make with other new social forces or with the labour movement. Its connotations of formality and permanence are at odds with the unevenness and spontaneity which have, for example, marked the history of anti-racist association. Under certain conditions black and white women may be able to make common cause, but they may also have different needs which result in conflicting demands in relation to, say, policing. The results of their encounters may be to disorganize each group yet they may still have important effects on the meaning and scope of class politics and organization. It is more important that these conflicts and combinations commence at the point where the tactical repertoire and analytical vocabulary of class starts to break down.

In organizational terms, many of the new social movements rely on mass mobilizational rather than mass membership. This is a tactic which has entered the political strategies of the women's and peace movements in Britain from black America's civil rights movement. The language of political relationships like Jesse Jackson's 'Rainbow Coalition' (Marable, 1985) may be important not only for its challenge to the central place of work-based politics but for the way it facilitates this activist orientation in the face of the bureaucratic mass membership strategy (Piven and Cloward, 1977) associated with electoral politics in general and the labour movement in particular.

Assessment of struggles apparently unrelated to class must pose the question of agency in its most acute form. How and why did the groups involved come to be organized? What are the limits of their action? What are its effects likely to bring for the future?

It is not just the content and effects of struggles around 'race' which reveal connections with class organization and politics. To the extent that they provide bases for collective action, the historical, cultural and kinship ties which give 'race' meaning must also be evaluated. How do these ties and the race consciousness which they foster compare with the forms of collective association based on work, wages and exploitation? They may overlap in the experience of black people who work, but even if they cannot be sublimated into discrete mutually exclusive categories, they need to be distinguished.

In a fascinating study, Craig Calhoun (1982) has looked at the heterogeneity and complexity of class in the context of popular radicalism during the first industrial revolution. He has identified several types of political language and mobilization which became grouped together under the term 'working class'. He distinguishes helpfully between workers who struggled 'on the basis of strong community foundations but against the preponderant forces of economic change' and those who 'fought on a weaker basis but within the emergent industrial order'. These groups are distinguished by their different places in relation to the process of industrialization, just as the groups I have been discussing can be distinguished according to their different positions within the processes of de-industrialization which have attended the second industrial revolution. Calhoun argues that 'both the social organisational basis and the consciousness which preceded the emergence of the modern working class were more likely foundations for radical collective action' than the class consciousness of the period. He views the politics of class as having created forms of action and consciousness which were less radical than traditional 'populist' movements centred on notions of community. Traditional communities are themselves viewed as 'the crucial social foundation for radical collective action'.

Calhoun identifies the roots of this diminishing radicalism in the 'development of formal organisations which could mobilize workers for national action. On an ideological level, the key to [it] was the development of an argument of exploitation based on the labour theory of value'. His differentiation of the complexity of class and its accompanying forms of radicalism can help to illuminate some of the ways that racial politics comes to fragment and disorganize the working class today.

I have pointed out elsewhere the use which black settlers have made of notions of community in their self-organization (Gilroy, 1981). Looking at the forms of collective action in which the idea of community has been prominent is also a means to connect the spatial and territorial dimensions of class formation with the political struggles discussed above (Katznelson, 1981). It raises the specificity of urban politics and of cities as locations in which the social division of labour achieves geographical expression. This is important because

the national economic crisis and the crisis of representation in the working-class movement display patterns of uneven territorial development. It may, therefore, become hard to distinguish the subjectivity based around 'race' from feelings of neighbourhood, region and locality. Black settlers who are concentrated in small areas within Britain's urban centres experience these connections in one form. The white racist for whom the presence of black neighbours becomes a symbol of urban degeneration experiences them differently.

It must also be repeated that radical ties and traditions which were formed in the nexus of imperial development and anti-colonial struggle are an enduring resource in the political practice of black Britain. These legacies are, of course, reshaped around the particular relations of exploitation and oppression which have arisen in post-war Britain. They have appeared not only in struggles around work (Beetham, 1970) but in the reproduction of classes and 'races' which becomes youth culture. The institutions they create: temples, churches, clubs, cafés and blues dances confound any Eurocentric idea of where the line dividing politics and culture should fall. The distinction between public and private spheres cuts through the life of their households and communities in a similar manner. Traditional solidarity mediates and adapts the institutions of the British political system against which it is defined. The varieties of radicalism constituted in this disorganic relationship, offer a profound challenge to anyone seeking to contain them within a concept of ethnicity.

The political consciousness of black settlers and their children draws on histories and memories of struggle beyond Britain's borders. They are combined, not only with the effects of insertion into an ailing industrial order at distinctive points but with the experience of banishment from production which has occurred with disproportionate frequency along lines marked by 'race'.

The history of this fusion is, for example, expressed in the continuity of protest which links the 1981 riots with the Health Service strike which followed them. Its economic dimensions are beyond the scope of this book but some of its cultural manifestations will be explored below. The social movement it has created out of poverty, exploitation and racial subordination is ideologically and organizationally distinct from the forms of political practice which emanate from the shrinking industrial core of the trades union and labour movements. Like Calhoun's early industrial labourers, the low-paid, black or female workers in today's public sector are not always well-served by the forms of organization which connect their grassroots activity through union membership to a bureaucracy premised on the need for co-ordinated national action. The traditional politics which defines the black communities and aids them in their radicalism inside and outside work, against the state as well as

against capital, must be claimed back from the superstructure and the ideological instance.

Race formation

A further word about the conception of 'race' which informs this chapter is now required. The forms of economic coercion involved in, for example, plantation slavery, migrant labour and apartheid, are all important reminders of the fact that 'race' can become a distinctive feature at the level of economic development. Having accepted this possibility, I have tried to demonstrate the advantages of emphasizing that 'race' is a political category that can accommodate various meanings which are in turn determined by struggle. In arguing this, I am not suggesting that the differences between individuals which come to be seen as 'racial' have an objective basis. These differences do not bear with them a unique or constant order of determinate effects which applies regardless of the conditions in which they have to exist. 'Race' has to be socially and politically constructed and elaborate ideological work is done to secure and maintain the different forms of 'racialization' which have characterized capitalist development. Recognizing this makes it all the more important to compare and evaluate the different historical situations in which 'race' has become politically pertinent.

This project does not lead inexorably to an idealist theory of 'race relations situations'. It can be used to introduce the idea of race formation.⁹ This refers both to the transformation of phenotypical variation into concrete systems of differentiation based on 'race' and colour and to the appeals to spurious biological theory which have been a feature of the history of 'races'. Race formation also includes the manner in which 'races' become organized in politics, particularly where racial differentiation has become a feature of institutional structures – legal subjectivity of citizenship – as well as individual interaction. If it is conceived as a continuous and contingent process in the same sense as class formation, race formation can also relate the release of political forces which define themselves and organize around notions of 'race' to the meaning and extent of class relationships. The concept supports the idea that racial meanings can change, can be struggled over. Rather than talking about racism in the singular, analysts should therefore be talking about racisms in the plural. These are not just different over time but may vary within the same social formation or historical conjuncture.

In this approach, biology cannot be wholly dismissed as a factor in the formation and reproduction of 'race'. It is better to confine phenotypes to a relatively autonomous realm of biological determinations which can ascribe a variety of social effects. Accepting that

skin 'colour', however meaningless we know it to be, has a strictly limited material basis in biology, opens up the possibility of engaging with theories of signification which can highlight the elasticity and the emptiness of 'racial' signifiers as well as the ideological work which has to be done in order to turn them into signifiers in the first place. This perspective underscores the definition of 'race' as an open political category, for it is struggle that determines which definition of 'race' will prevail and the conditions under which they will endure or wither away.

The contemporary politics of racial differentiation in this country illustrates this well. The naming of 'races' here has recently undergone a significant shift. It has moved away from political definitions of black based on the possibility of Afro-Asian unity and towards more restricted alternative formulations which have confined the concept of blackness to people of African descent. This process has occurred despite the unifying tendencies of racist activity which regards the racial characteristics of both 'Pakis' and 'niggers' as being equally worthy of hatred. This development has its origins in an understanding of 'race' which stresses the obstacles to political accommodation erected between groups by culture and ethnicity. Its conception of cultural differences as fixed, solid almost biological properties of human relations is, as we shall see in the next chapter, similar to the theory of 'racial' and national differences propounded by the radical right. It has been amplified and reflected politically in special state policy and provision for 'ethnic minorities' (invariably defined so that they coincide with the old idea of biological 'races'). These policy initiatives have played a part in the fracturing of the inclusive definition of black. They have institutionalized the desire to meet minority needs which are perceived to be distinct and separate though formally equal. Ethnic minority provision on independent television's Channel 4 provides an important case study of this fracturing process (Gilroy, 1983).

These ideas about the cultural limits of 'race' have been encouraged by the development of specifically 'anti-racist' interventions by local state apparatuses. They have become associated with a resurgent black nationalism and expressed in a layer of political activity often itself funded by local government. A variety of pseudo-pluralism has been fostered in which a culturally defined ethnic particularity has become the basis of political association. The degree to which the anti-racist strategy of local governments has relied on ideas of absolute cultural difference between ethnic and 'racial' groups to systematize its own funding policies must be explored in depth. The causality of these developments is difficult to identify. However, the movement towards this understanding of 'race' dates precisely from the aftermath of the 1981 riots and is intimately bound up with governmental responses to those protests. Chapter 4 will demonstrate

how the struggle among blacks over the scope and meaning of 'race' overlaps with the way in which 'race' has been defined and addressed politically by the agencies of the local state. The campaign to secure parliamentary places for black MPs and for the development of 'black sections' inside the Labour Party has been one of very few voices holding on to the idea of Afro-Asian unity although in their case, the political basis for this alliance remains vague (Proffitt, undated).

The most urgent task facing analysis of 'race' and racism in Britain involves identifying the limits to forms of political action in which the structures of racial feeling are uppermost.

The processes of 'race' and class formation are not identical. The former is not reducible to the latter even where they become mutually entangled. The very emptiness of racial signifiers, the sense in which 'race' is meaningless, contains a warning that its political vitality and volatility may increase as the practices and ideologies which comprise it become less stable and more contradictory. The evolution of racism from vulgar to cultural forms described by Fanon has introduced a new variety which stresses complex difference rather than simple hierarchy (Fanon, 1967). Thus today's British racism, anchored in national decline rather than imperial expansion overseas, does not necessarily proceed through readily apparent notions of superiority and inferiority. The order of racial power relations has become more subtle and elusive than that. Recognizing this fundamental development provides part of the key to understanding how radical and conservative, socialist and openly racist theories and explanations of 'race' have been able to converge dramatically. This coming together is a characteristic feature of contemporary 'race' politics in Britain and is explored in the next chapter.

Notes and references

- 1 I am taking Robert Miles's (1982) analysis of the sub-discipline as my starting point. I am in broad agreement with his criticisms of the positions outlined by Banton, Banton and Harwood and Rex.
- 2 See Johanna Brenner and Maria Ramas, 'Re-Thinking Women's Oppression', *New Left Review* 144, March/April 1984, and the replies by Michelle Barrett in *NLR* 146, July/August 1984, and Jane Lewis in *NLR* 149, January/February 1985, for an indication of recent debates over the relationship between women's oppression and class relations. The biological arguments in Brenner and Ramas's position offer an important opportunity to link analysis of women's subordination with investigation into 'race' and racism. They are careful to state their opposition to any form of biological determinism. The authors argue: 'We do propose . . . to take seriously Timpanaro's suggestion that the relationship between

the natural and the social must be built into the analysis' (p. 47). On the relative autonomy of biology see Timpanaro (1972) and Soper in Mepham and Hillel-Rubin (eds) (1979).

- 3 *Race Today* March/April 1983. For a critical discussion of this position see Hall *et al.* (1979), chapter 10.
- 4 For a crisp summary of the biological arguments around 'race' see Rose and Lewontin (1983). Benedict (1943) is also of interest.
- 5 On the 'Historic Bloc' see Buci-Glucksmann (1980), chapter 12, sections 5 and 6. For clarification of how the idea of Authoritarian Populism has been used in the context of contemporary Britain see Hall (1985) and the two articles by Jessop *et al.* *NLR* 147, September/October 1984, *NLR* 153, September/October 1985.
- 6 The work of the Greater London Council's Police Committee Support Unit set up by the Labour administration in 1982 illustrates this point. In the period between January 1982 and April 1986, when the GLC was abolished, the unit funded the work of numerous community and research-based projects into policing and produced a wide variety of informational and campaigning materials relating to the politics of policing and criminal justice matters. Some of the most important initiatives undertaken by this unit included the publication of the newsletter *Policing London*, the production of videos, travelling exhibitions, posters, leaflets and Ranking Ann's anti-police bill record 'Kill The Police Bill' on the unit's own 'Rough Justice' label in 1984.
- 7 A well attended rally: 'Black People's Solidarity with the Miners' was held at London's County Hall on 7 December 1984. It featured various cultural performances and speakers from various groups including the Asian Collective of East London, the Black Consciousness Movement, and the Pan-African Congress. The leaflet by which the event was organized included these lines:

Black People Say – Miners Must Win! No Pit Closures!! No Job Losses!!!
As Black People We Know what it is to be under seize [sic] as a community
As Black People we know what is state violence
As Black people we know what is unemployment
Our Struggle, Miners Struggle.
The same Miners Complete Victory Is Our Victory. Miners Defeat is not only our defeat but defeat of all workers. The experience of Irish people, Black People and The Miners are Same.

- 8 Gorz (1982) is one of the writers who has clearly argued that Marx's view of the proletariat as a universal class is evidence of residual Hegelianism even in his mature work. See also Jean-François Lyotard's 'Complexity and The Sublime' in (ed.) Appignanesi (1986). This point will be developed further in Chapter 6 below.
- 9 The concept of 'race formation' can be used following Bhaskar's advice to distinguish between the different ways in which 'race' and racism appear in the world agents and in the structures they create. It allows for a complex view of the articulation between the two:

It should be understood as a process: (1) through which an unstable and contradictory set of social practices and beliefs are articulated in an ideology based fundamentally on race; (2) through which the particular ideology thus generated is enforced by a system of racial subjection having both institutional and individual means of reproduction at its disposal; and (3) through which new instabilities and contradictions emerge at a subsequent historical point and challenge the pre-existing system once more (Omi and Winant, 1983).

2 'The whisper wakes, the shudder plays': 'race', nation and ethnic absolutism

The Queen Mother swayed in a gentle dance when one of three steel bands began playing a lilting reggae tune. Five yards away, swaying with her, were a group of Rastafarians wearing the red, yellow and green tea cosy hats which are the badge of their pot-smoking set (*Daily Mail*, 21.4.83).

The nation has been and is still being, eroded and hollowed out from within by implantation of unassimilated and unassimilable populations. . . alien wedges in the heartland of the state (Enoch Powell, 9.4.76).

Methinks I see in my mind a noble and puissant Nation rousing herself like a strong man after sleep, and shaking her invincible locks (Milton).

Racism has been described above as a discontinuous and unevenly developed process. It exists in plural form, and I have suggested that it can change, assuming different shapes and articulating different political relations. Racist ideologies and practices have distinct meanings bounded by historical circumstances and determined in struggle. This chapter moves away from general argument to focus on the distinctive characteristics of the racism which currently runs through life in Britain.

This particular form, which Martin Barker (1981) and others¹ have labelled 'the new racism', will be examined below with a view to focusing on the nature of its newness – the job it does in rendering our national crisis intelligible. It will be argued that its novelty lies in the capacity to link discourses of patriotism, nationalism, xenophobia, Englishness, Britishness, militarism and gender difference into a complex system which gives 'race' its contemporary meaning. These themes combine to provide a definition of 'race' in terms of culture and identity. What new right philosopher John Casey has called 'The whole life of the people'.² 'Race' differences are displayed in culture which is reproduced in educational institutions and, above all, in family life. Families are therefore not only the nation in microcosm, its key components, but act as the means to turn social processes into natural, instinctive ones.

These ideas have hosted an extraordinary convergence between left and right, between liberals and conservatives and between racists and some avowed anti-racists. These politically opposed groups have come together around an agreed definition of what 'race' adds up